



TOP 15 HISTORIC FORTS

of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj

Fort Architecture, History & the Role of Swarajya



Forts: The Backbone of Swarajya

Why Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj built his kingdom around fortified strongholds



Hill Forts (Giri-durg)

The majority of Swarajya's strongholds sat atop the steep, table-topped hills of the Sahyadri range. Their height and difficult approach made large-scale assault costly, letting a small garrison hold territory against much larger armies.



Coastal / Sea Forts (Jal-durg)

Built or expanded along the Konkan coastline, forts such as Sindhudurg and Vijaydurg protected trade and gave the new Maratha navy secure harbours from which to challenge the Siddis of Janjira and European trading powers.



Strategic Route Forts

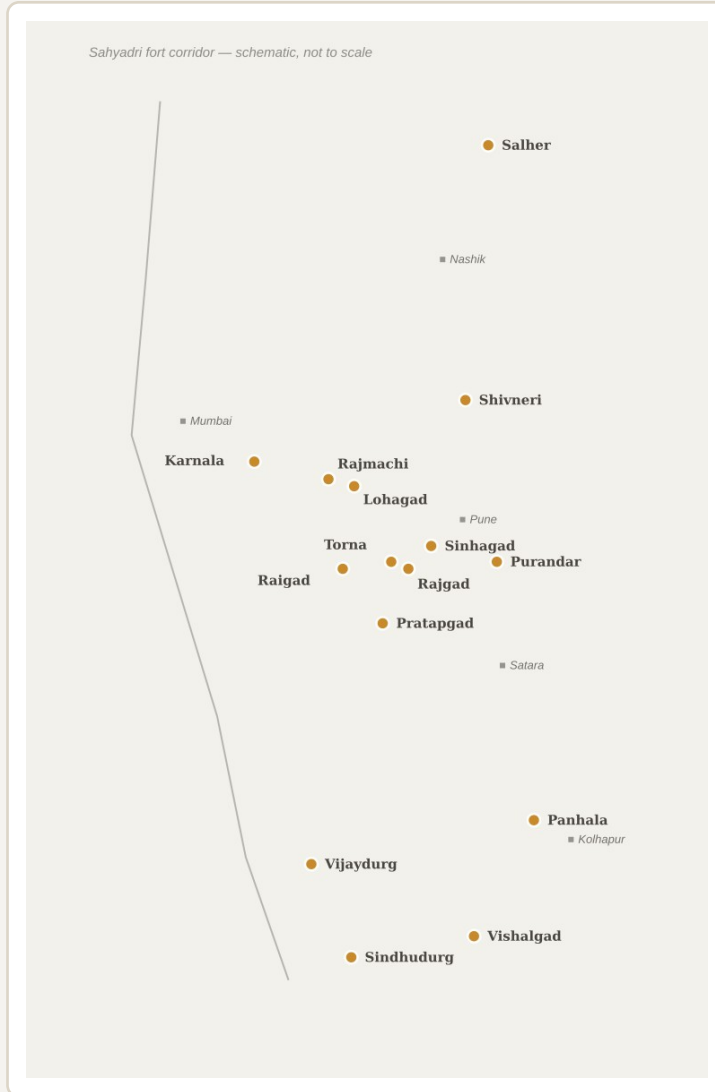
Forts guarding mountain passes (ghats) and trade routes — like Lohagad, Rajmachi and Karnala — controlled the flow of goods, revenue and troops between the Konkan coast and the Deccan plateau.

Together, this connected network of forts allowed Shivaji Maharaj to establish, expand and defend an independent Maratha state — Swarajya — against the far larger Mughal, Adilshahi and Siddi powers surrounding it.



The Fifteen Forts on the Map

Approximate locations across the Sahyadri (Western Ghats) corridor of Maharashtra



● Fort location ■ Reference city

Most forts cluster along the Sahyadri hill belt between Nashik and Kolhapur, with Sindhudurg and Vijaydurg guarding the Konkan coast further west and Salher marking the northern frontier near Baglan.





Shivneri Fort

Junnar Fort • Junnar, Pune District, Maharashtra

Hill fort

HISTORY

- Ancient hill fort, likely raised under the Yadavas of Devagiri
- Later held by the Bahmani Sultanate, then the Nizamshahi (Ahmadnagar) kingdom
- Shivaji's grandfather Maloji Bhosale served as a Nizamshahi jagirdar here

ROLE IN SHIVAJI'S SWARAJYA

- Birthplace of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj (19 Feb 1630)
- Sheltered Jijabai and infant Shivaji during a turbulent political period
- Revered as the symbolic starting point of Swarajya, though not a later military conquest of Shivaji

KEY EVENTS

- **1630** Birth of Shivaji Maharaj
- **1637** Fort passed from Nizamshahi rule to the Mughals
- **1673** Brief, unsuccessful Maratha attempt to retake the fort

SHIVAJI MAHARAJ'S ASSOCIATION

Associated with Shivaji from his birth in 1630; remained under Mughal / Bijapur control for most of his later life





Shivneri Fort

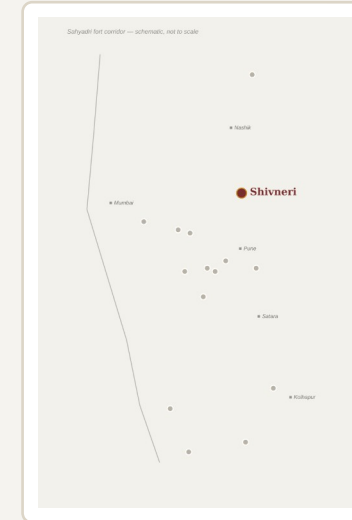
Architecture, Location & Legacy

■ ARCHITECTURAL FEATURES

- Seven consecutive fortified gates along a winding entry path
- Shivai Devi temple, after whom Shivaji was named
- Badami Talav — almond-shaped stepped water tank
- Ganga & Jamuna springs, said to have provided water at Shivaji's birth
- Small birth-chamber shrine (Shivkunj) on the upper plateau



Hill fort



Location within Maharashtra

DID YOU KNOW?

The fort is built on a spur shaped like a shark's fin, with seven gates designed so that no two are visible to each other at once — a defence against sudden storming.



Torna Fort

Prachandagad • Velhe, Pune District, Maharashtra

HISTORY

- An old hill fort referenced in Deccan records from at least the 13th–14th century
- Passed through Bahmani, Nizamshahi and Adilshahi (Bijapur) control before 1646

ROLE IN SHIVAJI'S SWARAJYA

- The first fort captured by a teenage Shivaji Maharaj in 1646, traditionally marking the start of Swarajya
- Its rugged, near-inaccessible ridge made it a natural stronghold guarding the routes toward Rajgad and the Konkan
- Treasure reportedly recovered here helped finance new construction at nearby Rajgad

KEY EVENTS

- **1646** Captured by Shivaji Maharaj; renamed Prachandagad
- **1704** Besieged and taken by Mughal forces under Aurangzeb
- **1705** Recaptured by the Marathas

Hill fort

SHIVAJI MAHARAJ'S ASSOCIATION

1646 onward — Shivaji's first conquest and an early anchor of Swarajya





Torna Fort

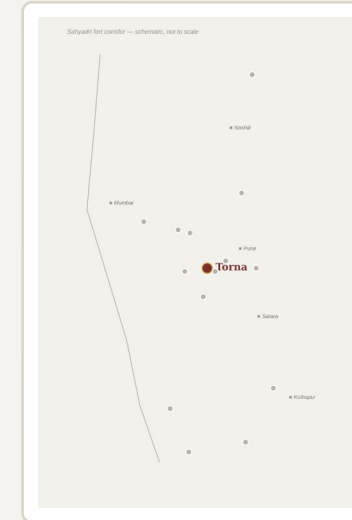
Architecture, Location & Legacy

■ ARCHITECTURAL FEATURES

- Massive walls following the natural rock contours of the ridge
- Budhla Machi and Zunjar Machi — fortified spur bastions on either flank
- Menghai Devi temple near the fort entrance
- Kothi Darwaza and ruined granary structures



Hill fort



Location within Maharashtra

DID YOU KNOW?

Local tradition holds that Shivaji found a hoard of gold coins during the fort's repair, which he used to help build Rajgad nearby.



Rajgad Fort

Murumdev (earlier name) • Gunjavane, Pune District, Maharashtra

HISTORY

- Originally a modest hill fort called Murumdev under Bahmani and later Adilshahi control
- Taken over and greatly strengthened after Shivaji secured the region in the mid-1640s

ROLE IN SHIVAJI'S SWARAJYA

- Served as the capital of Swarajya for about 26 years (c.1645–1674)
- Functioned as Shivaji's main administrative, military and family residence before Raigad
- Its three fortified spurs (machis) allowed defence in depth and control of surrounding passes

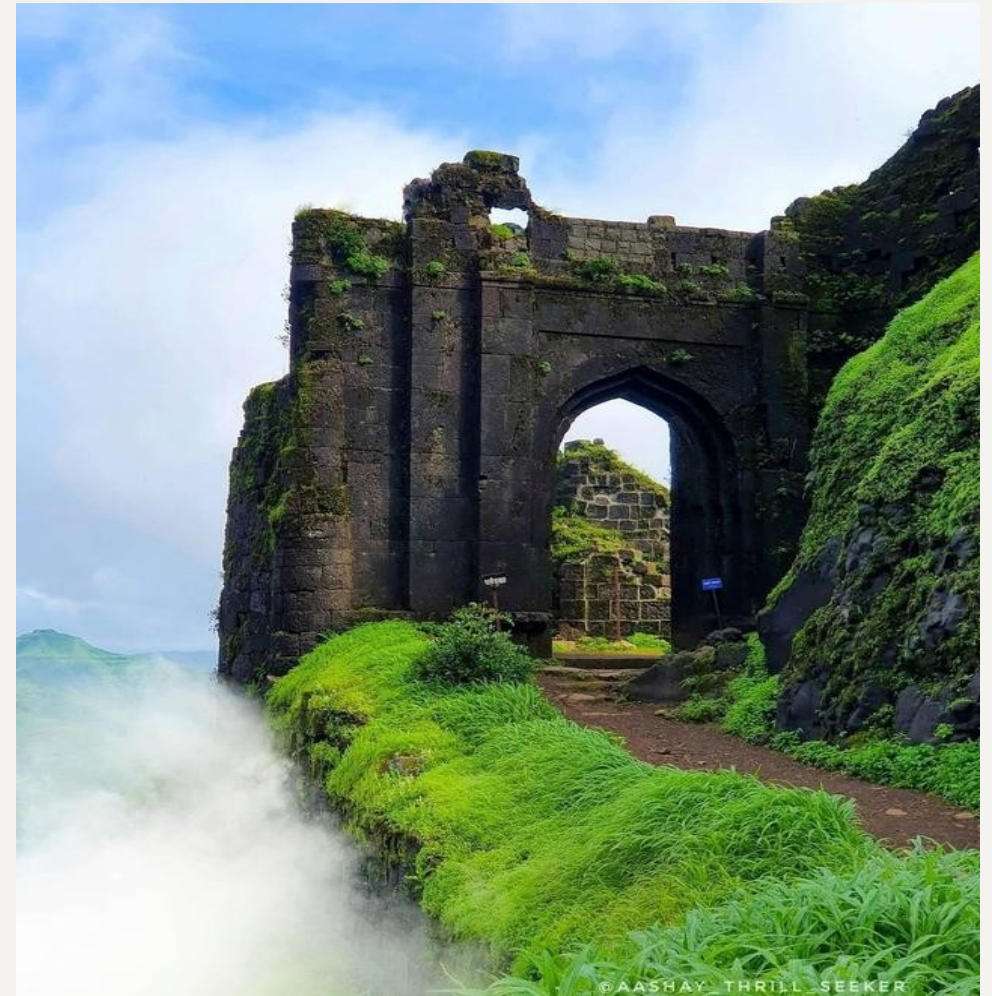
KEY EVENTS

- **c.1645** Established as the capital of Swarajya
- **1662** Sanjeevani Machi fortifications strengthened
- **1674** Jijabai (Shivaji's mother) passes away here shortly after his coronation

Hill fort

SHIVAJI MAHARAJ'S ASSOCIATION

c.1645–1674 — capital of Swarajya before the shift to Raigad





Rajgad Fort

Architecture, Location & Legacy

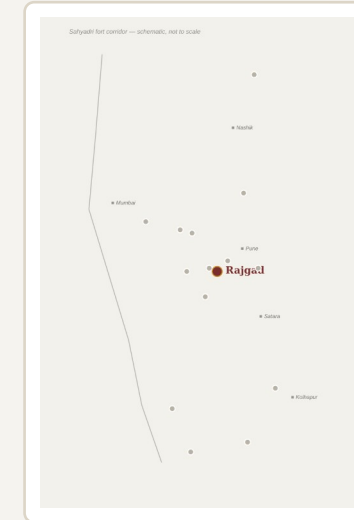
ARCHITECTURAL FEATURES

- Three machis — Padmavati, Sanjeevani and Suvela — radiating from the central citadel
- Balekilla (royal citadel) on the summit with palace foundations
- Padmavati temple and royal granaries
- Chor Darwaza — a concealed escape gate
- Extensive stepped water cisterns cut into rock



Rajgad Fort (2/2)

Hill fort



Location within Maharashtra

DID YOU KNOW?

Rajgad remained Shivaji's primary base for nearly three decades — longer than any other fort — earning it the title "Raja-gad", the King of Forts.



Raigad Fort

Rairi (earlier name) • Mahad, Raigad District, Maharashtra

Hill fort

HISTORY

- Originally a smaller fort called Rairi, held by the local chieftain Chandrarao More
- Annexed by Shivaji Maharaj in 1656 after the defeat of the More family

ROLE IN SHIVAJI'S SWARAJYA

- Rebuilt and declared the new capital of Swarajya in 1674 for its central, defensible location
- Site of Shivaji Maharaj's formal coronation as Chhatrapati on 6 June 1674
- Housed the royal court, mint, treasury and administration of the growing Maratha state

KEY EVENTS

1656 Captured by Shivaji Maharaj

1674 Coronation of Shivaji as Chhatrapati; declared capital

1680 Death of Shivaji Maharaj at Raigad

1689 Fort falls to Mughal forces after a prolonged siege

SHIVAJI MAHARAJ'S ASSOCIATION

1656 capture; capital of Swarajya from 1674 until 1689





Raigad Fort

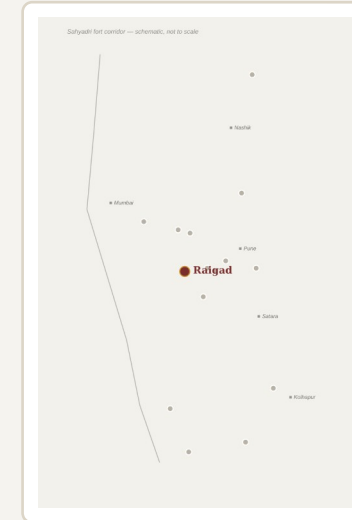
Architecture, Location & Legacy

ARCHITECTURAL FEATURES

- Maha Darwaza (main gate) and the imposing Hirakani Buruj bastion
- Raja Sabha — the coronation hall with the royal throne platform
- Bazarpeth — a fortified market street lined with shop foundations
- Ganga Sagar Lake, Jagdishwar temple, and Shivaji Maharaj's samadhi (memorial)
- Nagarkhana (drum-house) gate structure



Hill fort



Location within Maharashtra

DID YOU KNOW?

British traveller descriptions likened Raigad's approach — a single narrow stairway of over 1,700 steps — to a natural fortress gate that made the summit nearly impregnable.



Pratapgad Fort

Near Mahabaleshwar, Satara District, Maharashtra

HISTORY

- Unlike most forts on this list, Pratapgad was newly built rather than captured
- Constructed around 1656 on Shivaji's orders, supervised by Moropant Pingle, to guard the Par Ghat pass

ROLE IN SHIVAJI'S SWARAJYA

- Built specifically to secure a strategic Konkan-facing mountain pass
- Became the stage for the decisive meeting between Shivaji Maharaj and the Bijapur general Afzal Khan
- The resulting Maratha victory broke Bijapur's military threat and dramatically boosted Swarajya's standing

KEY EVENTS

1656 Fort construction completed

10 Nov 1659 Shivaji Maharaj kills Afzal Khan in their fortified meeting;
Maratha forces rout the Bijapur army

Hill fort

SHIVAJI MAHARAJ'S ASSOCIATION

Built c.1656; site of the pivotal 1659 encounter with Afzal Khan





Pratapgad Fort

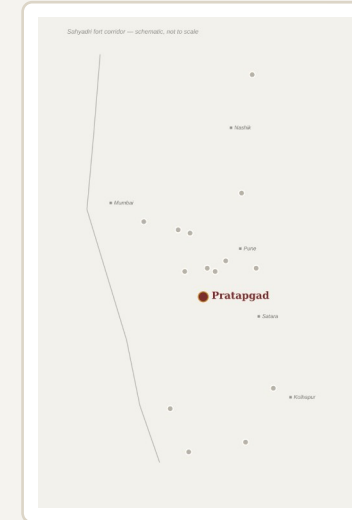
Architecture, Location & Legacy

ARCHITECTURAL FEATURES

- Distinct upper fort (Balekilla) and lower fort connected by fortified paths
- Bhavani Mandir, where Shivaji is said to have installed a Bhavani idol before the battle
- Afzal Khan's tomb at the base of the fort
- Strong bastions with commanding views over the Konkan lowlands



Hill fort



Location within Maharashtra

DID YOU KNOW?

The steel "wagh nakh" (tiger claws) associated with the Afzal Khan encounter remain one of the most famous artefacts in Maratha popular memory.



Sinhagad Fort

Kondhana (earlier name) • Near Pune city, Maharashtra

HISTORY

- An ancient fort known as Kondhana, held successively by Bahmani and Adilshahi (Bijapur) rulers
- Ceded to the Mughals under the 1665 Treaty of Purandar

ROLE IN SHIVAJI'S SWARAJYA

- Recaptured in a daring night assault on 4 February 1670 led by Tanaji Malusare, using rope-and-lizard climbing techniques on a sheer cliff face
- Tanaji was killed in the fierce fighting; the fort was renamed Sinhagad ("Lion's Fort") in his honour
- Its recapture symbolised the Maratha resurgence after the setbacks of 1665

KEY EVENTS

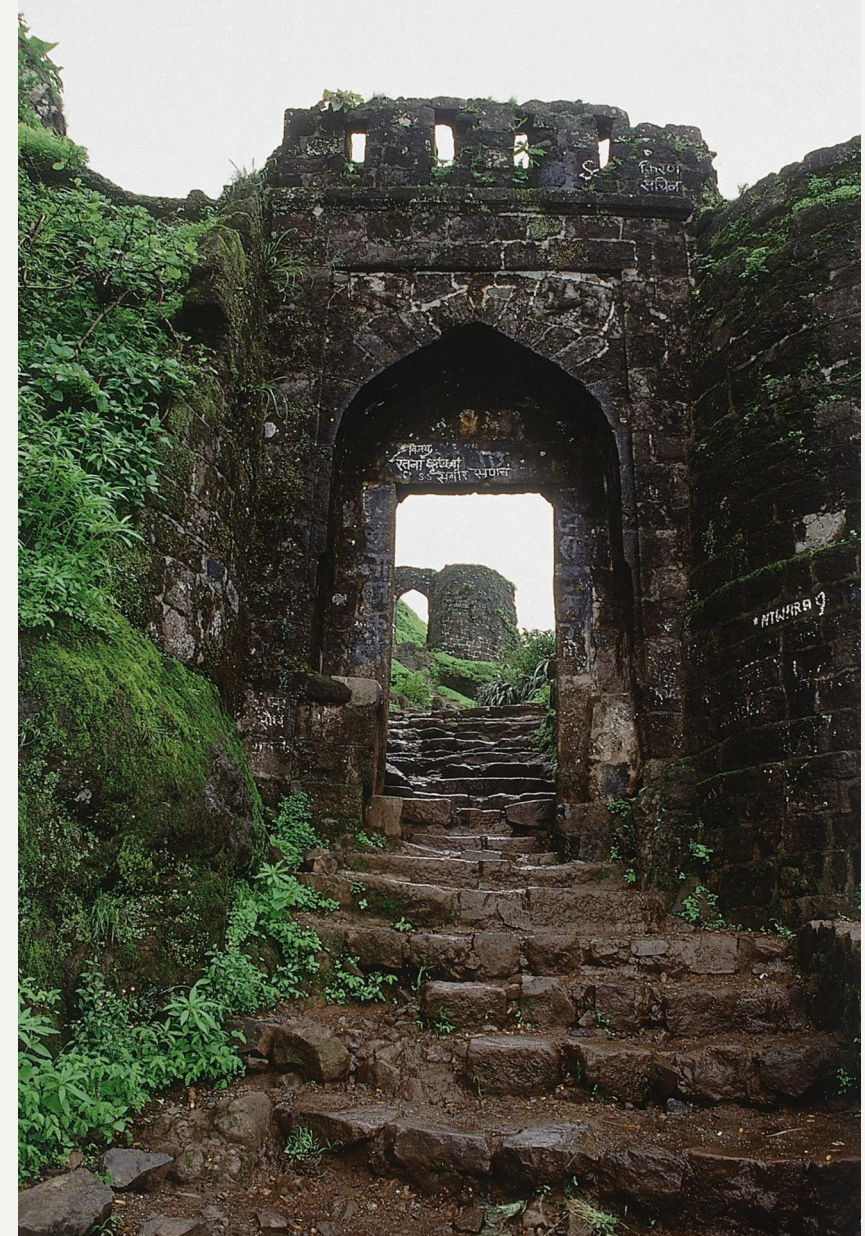
1665 Ceded to the Mughals under the Treaty of Purandar

4 Feb 1670 Battle of Sinhagad — Tanaji Malusare recaptures the fort and dies in battle

SHIVAJI MAHARAJ'S ASSOCIATION

Recaptured in 1670; held by the Marathas thereafter

Hill fort





Sinhagad Fort

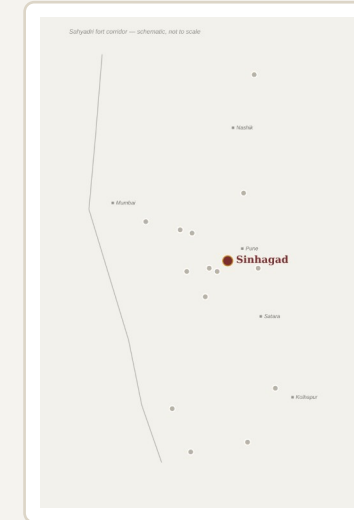
Architecture, Location & Legacy

ARCHITECTURAL FEATURES

- Kalyan Darwaza and Pune Darwaza — the fort's two main gates
- Tanaji Malusare's memorial near the point of assault
- Amruteshwar temple and Dev Tak water tank
- Zunjar Buruj bastion with sheer rock-face defences



Hill fort



Location within Maharashtra

DID YOU KNOW?

Shivaji Maharaj is said to have remarked on hearing of Tanaji's death, "Gad ala pan Sinha gela" — "The fort is won, but the lion is lost."



Purandar Fort

Twin fort with Vajragad • Saswad, Purandar Taluka, Pune District, Maharashtra

Hill fort

HISTORY

- An ancient fort with roots in Bahmani, Nizamshahi and Adilshahi rule before coming under Shivaji's control in the late 1640s
- Twin-fortified with the adjoining Vajragad on the same ridge

ROLE IN SHIVAJI'S SWARAJYA

- Served as an important early military base and treasury for Swarajya
- Site of the fierce 1665 siege where commander Murarbaji Deshpande died defending the fort against Mirza Raja Jai Singh
- The resulting Treaty of Purandar (1665) forced Shivaji to cede 23 forts to the Mughals, but preserved the core of Swarajya

SHIVAJI MAHARAJ'S ASSOCIATION

Under Maratha control from the late 1640s; briefly ceded in 1665, recovered in 1670

KEY EVENTS

- **1657** Birth of Sambhaji, Shivaji's son and successor
- **1665** Siege of Purandar and the Treaty of Purandar with Mirza Raja Jai Singh
- **1670** Recaptured by the Marathas





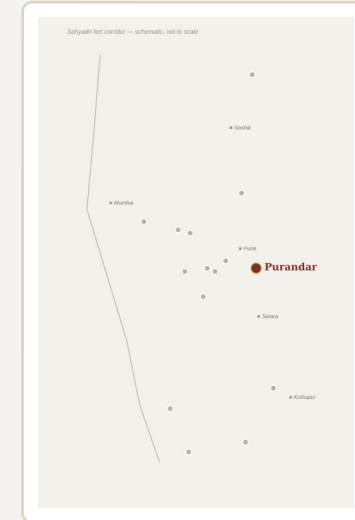
Purandar Fort

Architecture, Location & Legacy

ARCHITECTURAL FEATURES

- Twin summits of Purandar and Vajragad linked by a fortified saddle
- Bini Darwaza and Delhi Darwaza gates with deep dry moats
- Kedareshwar temple on the upper plateau
- Ruins of administrative buildings and water cisterns

Hill fort



Location within Maharashtra

Purandar Fort
01/07/2012
S.G.Isave, Pune

DID YOU KNOW?

The 1665 Treaty of Purandar was the only formal treaty Shivaji ever signed with the Mughals — and he began reversing its terms within five years.



Panhala Fort

Panhalgad • Near Kolhapur city, Maharashtra

Hill fort

HISTORY

- Built by the Shilahara king Bhoja II in the 12th century
- Later held by the Bahmani Sultanate and then the Adilshahi (Bijapur) kingdom
- One of the largest hill forts in the Deccan by area

ROLE IN SHIVAJI'S SWARAJYA

- Captured by Shivaji Maharaj in 1659, extending Swarajya into the Kolhapur region
- Besieged by the Bijapur general Siddi Jauhar in 1660, trapping Shivaji inside for months
- Scene of Shivaji's celebrated night escape to Vishalgad, covered by Baji Prabhu Deshpande's rearguard stand

KEY EVENTS

1659 Captured by Shivaji Maharaj

1660 Siege of Panhala by Siddi Jauhar; Shivaji's escape to Vishalgad

1673 Recaptured by the Marathas after a period of Bijapur control

Panhala Fort (1/2)

SHIVAJI MAHARAJ'S ASSOCIATION

1659 capture; contested through 1660s, secured firmly by 1673





Panhala Fort

Architecture, Location & Legacy

ARCHITECTURAL FEATURES

- Teen Darwaza — an imposing triple-gated entrance
- Ambarkhana — three linked granary structures (Ganga, Jamuna, Saraswati)
- Sajja Kothi, traditionally linked to Sambhaji's later imprisonment
- Andhar Bavṛī — a concealed stepped well

Hill fort



Location within Maharashtra

DID YOU KNOW?

Panhala changed hands so often in the 17th century that Maratha chronicles describe it as being "won thrice" by Shivaji and his successors.



Vishalgad Fort

Khelna (earlier name) • Shahuwadi Taluka, Kolhapur District, Maharashtra

Hill fort

HISTORY

- An old fort of Shilahara-Yadava origin, later held by the Adilshahi (Bijapur) kingdom
- Came under Maratha control around 1659 as Shivaji expanded through the Kolhapur region

ROLE IN SHIVAJI'S SWARAJYA

- Destination of Shivaji Maharaj's escape from the siege of Panhala in 1660
- Reached safely only because of the rearguard stand of Baji Prabhu Deshpande and Fuloji at Ghod Khind
- The pass was renamed Pavan Khind ("sacred pass") in honour of their sacrifice

KEY EVENTS

c.1659 Comes under Maratha control

13 Jul 1660 Battle of Pavan Khind; Shivaji reaches Vishalgad safely

SHIVAJI MAHARAJ'S ASSOCIATION

c.1659–60 — closely tied to the Panhala escape





Vishalgad Fort

Architecture, Location & Legacy

■ ARCHITECTURAL FEATURES

- Three concentric tiers of fortification following the hill's contours
- Samadhis (memorials) of Baji Prabhu and Fuloji Deshpande near Pavan Khind
- Amruteshwar temple on the plateau
- Remnants of watchtowers along the ridge



Hill fort



Location within Maharashtra

DID YOU KNOW?

Baji Prabhu Deshpande reportedly held the narrow pass with a small band of men just long enough to hear the sound of cannon fire confirming Shivaji had reached Vishalgad safely.



Sindhudurg Fort

Malvan, Sindhudurg District, Maharashtra

Coastal / sea fort

HISTORY

- Built entirely new on Kurte island by Shivaji Maharaj, with no earlier ruler occupying the site
- Construction began around 1664–65, reportedly guided by the architect Hiroji Indurkar

ROLE IN SHIVAJI'S SWARAJYA

- Anchored Shivaji's growing naval power along the Konkan coast
- Countered the Siddis of Janjira as well as Portuguese and English trading interests
- Served as the principal headquarters of the early Maratha navy (Aarmar)

KEY EVENTS

1664–67 Fort constructed on Shivaji's orders

Late 1600s Established as the main base of the Maratha navy

SHIVAJI MAHARAJ'S ASSOCIATION

1664–67 — purpose-built as a naval stronghold





Sindhudurg Fort

Architecture, Location & Legacy

Coastal / sea fort

ARCHITECTURAL FEATURES

- Roughly 3 km of massive basalt walls, up to 9 m high, with iron-clamped foundations
- 42 bastions positioned to command the surrounding sea approaches
- Freshwater wells that remain sweet despite the surrounding seawater
- A shrine said to preserve Shivaji Maharaj's handprint and footprint
- Shri Shivrajeshwar temple, built later by his son Rajaram in his memory



Location within Maharashtra

DID YOU KNOW?

Local tradition holds that the fort's foundations were sealed with molten lead to withstand the pounding of the Arabian Sea — an engineering feat unusual for its time.



Vijaydurg Fort

Gheria (earlier name) • Devgad, Sindhudurg District, Maharashtra

Coastal / sea fort

HISTORY

- Originally built by the Shilahara king Bhoja II in the 12th century
- Later held by the Adilshahi (Bijapur) kingdom before being taken and greatly expanded by Shivaji Maharaj in the 1650s–60s

ROLE IN SWARAJYA

- A key naval base and shipbuilding yard defending the Konkan coastline
- Its innovative submerged stone wall, hidden at high tide, was designed to wreck enemy ships approaching the harbour

KEY EVENT

- 18th century — Later served as the base of Kanhoji Angre's Maratha navy against European fleets

ARCHITECTURE

- Triple line of fortification walls with 27 bastions
- A concealed underwater defensive wall along the approach channel
- Dockyard facilities for building and repairing war vessels





Lohagad Fort

Twin fort with Visapur • Near Lonavala, Pune District, Maharashtra

Hill fort

HISTORY

- An old fort in the Sahyadri range, passed through Nizamshahi and Adilshahi control
- Captured by Shivaji Maharaj in 1648 during the early expansion of Swarajya

ROLE IN SWARAJYA

- Briefly ceded to the Mughals under the 1665 Treaty of Purandar, then recaptured in 1670
- Reportedly used to store treasure brought back from the 1664 raid on Surat
- Its connection to Visapur fort via the narrow "Vinchu Kata" ridge gave it strong natural defence

KEY EVENT

- 1670 — Recaptured by the Marathas; used to store Surat treasure

ARCHITECTURE

- Four gateways — Ganesh, Narayan, Hanuman and the Maha Darwaza
- Vinchu Kata ("scorpion's tail") — a narrow rock spur linking Lohagad to Visapur
- Rock-cut caves near the fort associated with earlier Buddhist activity in the region





Rajmachi Fort

Twin bastions: Shrivardhan & Manaranjan • Near Lonavala, Pune District, Maharashtra

Hill fort

HISTORY

- An old fort guarding the Bor Ghat trade route linking the Konkan coast to the Deccan plateau
- Held by earlier Deccan sultanates before coming under Maratha control around 1657

ROLE IN SWARAJYA

- Secured the vital Bor Ghat pass used for trade and troop movement between Konkan and Desh
- Garrisoned to protect Swarajya's supply and communication lines through the Sahyadris

KEY EVENT

- 18th century — Continued strategic use through the Peshwa period

ARCHITECTURE

- Twin peaks — Shrivardhan and Manaranjan — linked by a fortified plateau
- Bhairavnath temple and the adjoining Rajmachi village
- Commanding views over the Ulhas valley below





Salher Fort

Twin fort with Salher-Mulher • Baglan Region, Nashik District, Maharashtra

Hill fort

HISTORY

- An ancient hill fort in the Baglan region near the Gujarat border
- Under Mughal control from 1636, well before Shivaji's campaigns reached the area

ROLE IN SWARAJYA

- Site of the decisive Battle of Salher (February 1672) — a rare open-field pitched battle victory for the Marathas over a large Mughal force
- Led by generals Moropant Pingle and Prataprao Gujar, the victory secured the northern Baglan–Khandesh frontier
- Helped reverse territorial losses from the 1665 Treaty of Purandar

KEY EVENT

- Feb 1672 — Battle of Salher — decisive Maratha victory over a large Mughal army

ARCHITECTURE

- A vast summit plateau with extensive, now partly ruined fortification walls
- Twin-fort arrangement with neighbouring Mulher
- Remains of old temples on the plateau





Karnala Fort

Near Panvel, Raigad District, Maharashtra

Hill fort

HISTORY

- An old fort of the Konkan lowlands, held in turn by the Ahmadnagar and Bijapur sultanates
- Briefly contested by the Siddis and the Portuguese before Maratha control

ROLE IN SWARAJYA

- Captured by Shivaji Maharaj during his Konkan campaigns to secure the coastal lowlands near Kalyan and present-day Mumbai
- Ceded to the Mughals under the 1665 Treaty of Purandar, and later recaptured by the Marathas

KEY EVENT

- Later 1600s — Recaptured by the Marathas

ARCHITECTURE

- A distinctive needle-like rock pinnacle (minar) rising from the fort plateau
- Rock-cut water cisterns and ruined bastions
- Today surrounded by the Karnala Bird Sanctuary





Comparative Summary

The fifteen forts at a glance

Fort	Location	Type	Major Importance	Major Historical Event
Shivneri	Junnar, Pune	Hill fort	Birthplace of Shivaji Maharaj	Birth of Shivaji, 1630
Torna	Velhe, Pune	Hill fort	First fort captured; start of Swarajya	Capture, 1646
Rajgad	Pune	Hill fort	Capital of Swarajya, c.1645–74	Jijabai's death, 1674
Raigad	Mahad, Raigad	Hill fort	Capital & coronation site	Coronation, 1674
Pratapgad	Satara	Hill fort	Purpose-built strategic fort	Death of Afzal Khan, 1659
Sinhagad	Pune	Hill fort	Recaptured, guarding Pune	Battle of Sinhagad, 1670
Purandar	Saswad, Pune	Hill fort	Early military base & treasury	Treaty of Purandar, 1665
Panhala	Kolhapur	Hill fort	Largest Deccan fort; siege & escape	Siege of Panhala, 1660
Vishalgad	Kolhapur	Hill fort	Refuge fort after Panhala escape	Battle of Pavan Khind, 1660
Sindhudurg	Malvan	Coastal fort	Headquarters of the Maratha navy	Constructed 1664–67
Vijaydurg	Devgad	Coastal fort	Naval base & shipyard	Underwater defence wall
Lohagad	Lonavala, Pune	Hill fort	Treasury / storage fort	Recapture, 1670
Rajmachi	Lonavala, Pune	Hill fort	Guarded the Bor Ghat trade route	Secured c.1657
Salher	Baglan, Nashik	Hill fort	Tallest fort; northern frontier defence	Battle of Salher, 1672
Karnala	Panvel, Raigad	Hill fort	Guarded Konkan coast near Mumbai	Ceded in Treaty of Purandar, 1665



Conclusion

- No single fort made Swarajya possible — it was the connected network of hill, coastal and route forts that let Shivaji Maharaj hold and expand territory far beyond what his army's size alone could defend.
- Hill forts like Rajgad, Raigad and Torna gave Swarajya secure, near-impregnable centres of administration and command.
- Coastal forts like Sindhudurg and Vijaydurg extended Maratha power onto the Arabian Sea, checking the Siddis and European trading fleets.
- Route-guarding forts such as Lohagad, Rajmachi and Karnala controlled the ghats and passes that moved trade, revenue and troops between the Konkan and the Deccan.
- Together, this fort network allowed a regional kingdom to repeatedly absorb losses — as after the 1665 Treaty of Purandar — and still recover and expand, laying the foundation for the wider Maratha Empire that followed.



References & Sources

Information compiled from established heritage and historical sources

- Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) — protected monument records for individual forts
- Maharashtra Tourism Development Corporation (MTDC) — official fort and heritage-site information
- Maharashtra State Gazetteers, District Gazetteer volumes (Pune, Raigad, Satara, Kolhapur, Sindhudurg, Nashik)
- Sabhasad Bakhar and other traditional Maratha court chronicles (bakhars), as cited in standard secondary histories
- James Grant Duff, "A History of the Mahrattas" (1826) — early standard reference history
- Jadunath Sarkar, "Shivaji and His Times" — widely used academic history of the period
- G. B. Mehendale and other modern Marathi-language fort-history researchers
- District administration and forest/heritage department websites for individual forts (e.g. Raigad, Sindhudurg, Panhala)

Note: where sources differ on exact dates, the most commonly accepted account among these references has been used, with approximate years ("c.") shown where evidence is not precise.